

Intermission - "Gold and Gold"

— *Well then, I guess it's about time I gotta make up my mind about what the hell to do.*

???: [It really ain't in my nature to wait around in the first place. Despite that, given the fact I've waited so long, if anything, I should get some sorta award.]

Sitting cross-legged on a sofa worthy of the opulent guest room that had been prepared for her, Felt clicked her tongue.

Quite some time had passed since they had found some faults by which to undermine Felt, and detained her. — Naturally, Felt was aware that this attack on her was by extension an attack on the Royal Selection.

Although being held in custody at the Royal Castle was nominally out of concern for the safety of the Royal Candidates, in actuality it was house arrest. With their contact with others, correspondence via letters, and ability to procure information all restricted to a minimum, the vexing wait continued to pass.

Since she held not a single complaint over her basic necessities, it was truly ridiculous treatment.

Felt: [...Seems like that Reinhard bastard is doing all sorts of things.]

There was no way Reinhard, as her one and only Knight, did not grasp both the preferential treatment he was being given in this situation, and the misfortune this situation had placed him in. However, despite her wish to inquire as to the state of affairs, the chance to do so had never come, as the man himself had never appeared before her.

Felt: [Usually, just uttering his name, without even calling for him, is enough to make him pop up, and yet...]

It was precisely at times such as these that she found Reinhard so detestable, meticulously redrawing the lines of those boundaries he rather frequently crossed, never intending to show what lay within his heart. Nevertheless, this was not simply a problem with Reinhard; there was a very high probability that impediments beyond his control had been bestowed upon him.

After all, it was not only that useless Reinhard; there had not been any contact from Rom-jii either.

Felt: [I hope Rachins's gang were able to successfully meet up with Crusch-nee-chan and the others, but...]

Summoned to the Royal Castle, the only move Felt had been able to make before her one-sided hearing had been to send her followers out on an errand ahead of time, so that the turbulent situation would not slip from their grasp.

Seeing that she had not received any news from them either, it was difficult to hope for aid from her own followers— no, from anyone.

Felt: [I'd at least like to have some tools, but naturally they aren't *that* careless, huh?]

Just prior, it had been stated that she had possessed no complaints regarding everyday necessities, but in truth, she did. Her tableware had been limited to light wooden or ceramic options, unable to be used as weapons or tools. Of course, she had been given no knives from the start.

Felt's weapons consisted of only what information she had gleaned while in confinement. The number of guards, which she had counted using their footsteps, the time of changes in the guard calculated by counting backwards from mealtimes, and her profiling of the personalities of those among the soldiers assigned to monitor her with whom she had interacted with—— that was all she had.

Employing these to their utmost potential, Felt intended to escape her captivity. ——Ideally, she would bring along Emilia, who was likely also being detained here in the Castle.

Felt: [Even though we oughta be in the same castle, I don't get to meet her at all; they're being damn thorough... This is just how I gotta do things. If it were Emilia-nee-chan, she might end up doing something even more reckless.]

If it came to that, Emilia would unquestionably come to get Felt. She had no doubt about that, but since it was dubious whether Emilia would have a plan for anything that came after, it was somewhat preferable for Felt herself to be the one to act first, were either of them to make a move.

Therefore, Felt had decided to act during mealtime that day—— or so she had thought.

However——

Felt: [——Ahn?]

Having estimated the time of day based on the shadows visible in the courtyard through the window, Felt had been standing ready to take advantage of the imminent mealtime, but instead, she heard screams of pain outside the door from the guards whom she had intended to constrict herself.

Thus, upon witnessing the person whose face peeked through the slowly opened door, her eyes widened.

Felt: [...Well that's a mug I never thought I'd see here. Just so you know, it's been a damn while since I've seen your son's mug too.]

???: [——. Don't need you to be telling me that, I already know. For me, well, I've been passing by him every now and again.]

With those words, the one glaring at her with a bitter expression was a person for whom it was only natural for his features of red hair and blue eyes, and those features alone, to be shared with Felt's one and only Knight——,

???: [——Heinkel-sama, is it alright? Is it fine now? Nobody's there?]

Calling out Heinkel's name, a voice of verification from behind him could be heard. Having a clue as to the owner of that voice, the creases in Felt's brow deepened in perplexity over the development that had been even more unforeseen.

What made the deepened creases in her brow difficult to get rid of, was the person peeking oh so timidly through the gap in the door to look inside the room, thus meeting eyes with Felt——the presence of Filóre.

A visit from Heinkel, and Filóre; an arrangement that brought Felt quite a headache.

Felt: [It'd be damn bothersome even if I wasn't locked up, and yet, to think it'd happen while I'm imprisoned...]

Heinkel: [Hey, you should know there's limits to how disrespectful you can be. Even after Filóre-sama went out of her way to come meet you here...]

Filóre: [Now now now, it's fine, Heinkel-sama! It's clear that even if you argue with Felt over that matter, it will just be fruitless for everyone. More importantly, we ought to have a discussion that will bear fruit!]

Felt: [You're talking damn loud. A discussion that'll bear fruit?]

Heinkel displayed a bad attitude as per usual, and Filóre paid him a certain degree of respect.

If Felt's recollection from the time before her detainment was correct, when Filóre had decided to participate in the Royal Selection, it seemed like she had declared that she would name Heinkel as her Knight, thus plunging the Royal Castle into a state of confusion.

And judging by this, it seemed as though their master-servant contract had indeed materialized, but——,

Filóre: [Naturally, it's a discussion that will bear fruit! A bountiful harvest! As a matter of fact, Felt, I happened to think you would be growing impatient any time now. After all, the same went for me! How about it, was I spot-on?]

Felt: [...Well, I ain't gonna deny it. Though, when you say that you also got impatient, that'd be...]

Filóre: [——Let's have ourselves a prison break, Felt. With me, you, Emilia, all of us.]

Fully chewing through the words she had been told, Felt wordlessly gazed up at the ceiling.

To describe leaving the most magnificent castle in the nation as a prison break, was a manner of phrasing surprisingly to Felt's liking.

Felt: [Whether it be Emilia-nee-chan or Filóre... the hell's going on with us Royal Candidates?]

She began wanting to grumble such complaints.

——After all, now that her life under arrest had gone on for two months, it was an outrageously unexpected invitation.

《*Fin*》